

exists because the lack of wealth in certain areas prohibits these people from having the same housing, health care, etc. as the wealthy, in societies where these social goods depends on wealth.

Generally we can say that mainly inequality occurs in Bangladesh on the basis of prestige, power, wealth, rank, class, ethnicity etc. Social inequality has been long recognized both as the cause and as the effect of underdevelopment.

Culture

Definition of culture

Culture is everything made, learned, or shared by the members of a society, including values, beliefs, behaviors, and material objects.

Culture is learned, and it varies tremendously from society to society. We begin learning our culture from the moment we're born, as the people who raise us encourage certain behaviors and teach their version of right and wrong.

Culture combines many elements to create a unique way of living for different people. In this lesson, we identify four of the elements that exist in every culture, albeit in different forms: symbols, language, values, and norms. We also differentiate between folkways and mores.

Elements of culture

Language: Language, be it spoken, written, or gestured, is the basic means of communication between humans. It would be safe to say that language has evolved along with humans, originating with a combination of basic sounds, calls, and gestures to coherent speech, scripts, accents, and dialects. Rough estimates tell us that between 5000 to 7000 languages exist in our world today. Its function has long exceeded its basic use of communication. Languages now serve as a means of cultural identity, entertainment, and social status, grooming, and refinement.

Values: Another cultural element is a system of values, which are culturally defined standards for what is good or desirable. Members of the culture use the shared system of values to decide what is good and what is bad. For example, a person who accepts a

promotion in our culture is praised for their individual hard work and talent. But our values are in stark contrast with the collectivistic values of other cultures, where collaboration is encouraged, and a person's success is only as good as their contributions to the group.

Social Structure: In a broad sense, social structure or organization refers to a pattern of relationships between and among individuals and groups. These relationships or groups are created to augment the smooth functioning of society. Examples include nuclear and extended families, brotherhoods and sororities, labor unions, corporate organizations, governments, etc.

Customs and Traditions: Customs and traditions influence and govern each aspect of our behavior. These may be informal or formal in nature, and tend to vary from region to region. Customs develop over a long period, taking shape from our beliefs and lifestyles. They also tend to shift, evolve, and disappear as time progresses; but one aspect remains consistent—that these customs and rituals are an integral part of our evolutionary process and social behavior.

Arts: Human emotions and ideas have always found the perfect medium of expression in the arts. Arts encompass a wide range of forms, including literature, crafts, architecture, music, dance, dramatics, etc. The arts can be called the most vital aspect of human culture, as it signifies all that we have achieved in the past. It also serves as a useful medium for cultural preservation aimed at future generations.

Bangladeshi culture

Bangladesh is a country where colorful fairs and festivals are held throughout the year in a befitting manner. Some of the festivals bear the mark of the community and nation, some have the stamp of religion, and again some bear the impress of politics.

There is no reliable information about the historical origin of fairs but researchers claim that they started about 3000 years back. It is certain, though, that the early fairs expressed the collective joy of the ancient people. Today fairs are a mix of tradition and modernity. Some of the major fairs are described below:-

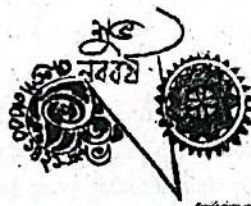


Eid-ul-Fitr and Eid-ul-Azha: The main Muslim festivals are Eid-ul-Fitr and Eid-ul-Azha. From time to time folk culture has influenced these festivals, as a result of which the original religious practices have changed. Eid-ul-Fitr is observed after the end of the month of Ramadan.

Durga Puja: The biggest religious festival of the Hindu community in Bangladesh is the festival of Durga Puja. Hindus participate in this festival with great devotion. Durga Puja is an old festival but it is difficult to say with any degree of certainty exactly how old it is.

Buddha Purnima, Baisakhi Purnima and Christmas day: Apart from the Hindus, there are also two other minority religions communities in Bangladesh, viz., the Christians and the Buddhists, who observe religious festivals of their own.

Baisakhi Mela: Celebrations of Pahela Baisakh started from Emperor Akbar's reign. It was customary to clear up all the year's dues on the last day of Chaitra (the twelfth month of the Bengali calendar). On the following day, or the first day of the new year, landlords would entertain their tenants with sweets. On this occasion fairs used to be organized there.



Amor Ekushey Grontho Mela (Book Fair): Amor Ekushey February is a historic day for the Bengali nation. On that day five valiant sons of this country laid down their lives to win recognition for Bangla as a

State language.

Muharram: Muharram or the 'sacred month' is the first month of the Islamic or Hijri calendar. The tenth day of Muharram is called Ashura. Imam Husain (R) the grandson of the Holy Prophet (SM) was killed on this day at the hands of the troops of Yazid.

Baisabi Festival: Baisabi is the main social festival of the indigenous people living in the hill districts of Rangamati, Bandarban and Khagrachhari. This festival is celebrated by the Chakma and Tanchyanga as "Biju", by Marmas as "Shangrai", Tripuras as "Baisuk" or "Baisu".

Dubla Rash Mela: Dubla Rash Mela is not only a big fair for Bagerhat, it is undoubtedly one of the biggest fairs in the country. At the centre of the festival are twenty thousand temporary fishermen who are engaged in catching and drying fish on Dubla and nearby islands. In the Bangla month of Agrahayan every year, the fair continues for 5-7 days during full moon time.

Fair of Adinath: Moheshkhali is an island under Cox's Bazar district not very far from the mainland. There, the Adinath temple at the top of Mainak hillock is a place of worship for Hindu devotees. A landlord named Nur Mohammad Shikdar donated 200 acres of land to reconstruct the age-old Adinath Temple. The fair associated with the temple started from that time.

Golakandail Fair: From the 1st day of the Bengali month of Mag - 7, a fair is held in Golakandail village of Rupganj upazila under Narayanganj district for seven days under a big banyan tree. Nobody knows the origin of the fair but it has continued for ages and is full of fun and festivity.

Gurpukur Fair: Every year the last day of the Bengali month of Bhadra is the occasion for worshipping the snake goddess (Monsha Puja), and a fair is held on the occasion at Shatkira in a place named Gurpukur.

Shib Chaturdashi Fair: A thousand-year-old Shiva temple stands at the top of the Chandranath hill located at Sitakunda in Chittagong where many other old temples are also situated in various parts of the 500 metre high hill. Thousands of devotees gather in the temple at night on 14th Falgun. The famous fair of Shib Chaturdashi continues for three days following religious rituals.

Langalbandh Fair: Every year on the 8th day of the lunar month falls in the Bengali month of Chaitra, thousands of Hindu devotees from home and abroad assemble on the banks of the old Brahmaputra river for Astami snan, a ritual bath in the river. On the

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a three-day fair is held in this place, starting before the day of Ashtami snan (bathing) and ending a day after the bathing ceremony.

Kothin Chibor Dan Fair: 'Kothin Chibor Dan' is a Buddhist ceremony on which occasion 'viksus' are given 'chibor' or cloth to wear. Buddhists believe that this is the best of all gifts. Chibor, the cloth that viksus wear, may be of any six colours: those of a tree's roots, trunk, bark, dry leaves, fruit or flower.

Fair of Ghoshbila: The fair is also known as Baruni fair. In fact, there is a ghat in the village Ghoshbila under Alamdanga upazila of Chuadanga district which is considered a holy place by the Hindus as a legend says that the goddess Ganga once appeared here. Since then a fair has been organized at that place to commemorate the day of her arrival.

Fair of Ashwin Sankranti: One of the renowned fairs of Rajshahi is held in a village of Durgapur upazila named Khulshi. The fair is held on the bank of the river for the first three days of the Bengali month of Ashwin.

Children's Amusement Fair: The Children's Academy has been organizing a children's amusement fair since 1978 in Dhaka. Usually the fair is organized in the open space in front of the Academy. Many stalls full of books, science exhibits, cane products, handicrafts, pottery, hand stitched items, children's art and wall newspaper are the attractions of the fair.

Baul Mela: On the occasion of Lalon Shah's birthday, the folk singers (Bauls) perform Lalon's songs, usually under a banyan tree or on the bank of a river near a village and a group of people organize a fair at the spot. Rural musical instruments, handicrafts, pottery, light snacks and household items are available in the fair which runs for three days or in some places one week or even longer than that.

Education

Education system of Bangladesh

The present education system of Bangladesh may be broadly divided into three major stages, viz primary, secondary and tertiary education. Primary level institutions impart